HONG KONG–SHENZHEN / AN EXPLORATORY STUDY

WHEN LIVES SPAN A BORDER

What do everyday experiences reveal about opportunities and adjustments?

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At JB Sentral

Research and presentation: Jamie Ko / Visual support: Bob / Field photographs supplied by Bob and Jamie

A Hong Kong-centred inquiry, returning to Singapore–Johor with questions. Pictured people are not identified as participants.

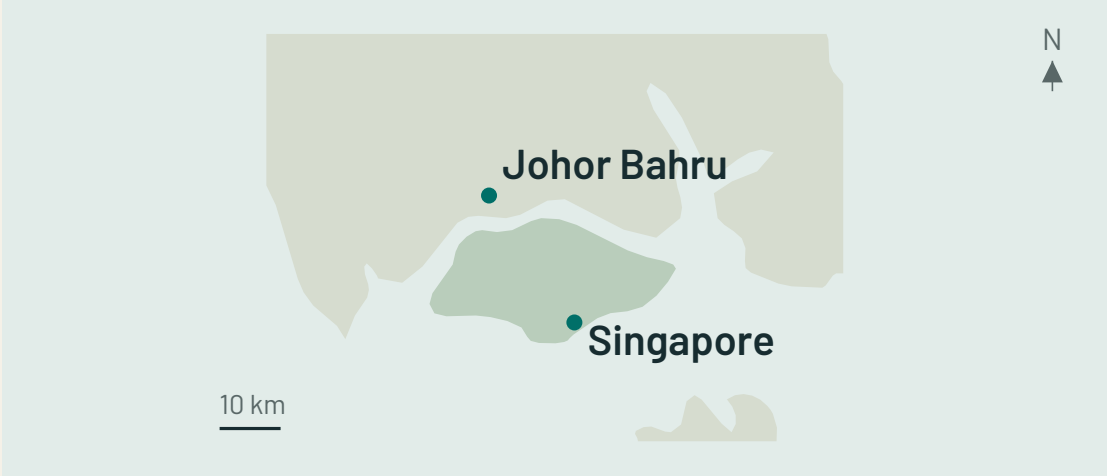
THE REGIONAL CONTEXT

A FAMILIAR QUESTION. DIFFERENT ARRANGEMENTS.



Hong Kong–Shenzhen

One country; different systems



Singapore–Johor

JS-SEZ in Johor / RTS is a separate rail link

MTI / EDB, JS-SEZ factsheet (2025) [1]; LTA / Malaysia MOT (2026) [2]; Natural Earth locator geometry

Selected places only; no zone or route boundaries shown. RTS target: February 2027, subject to approvals.

WHAT EXISTING RESEARCH TELLS US

DIFFERENT PARTS OF A CROSS-BORDER LIFE

2014

INTEGRATION

Economic, institutional and social processes

Shen / historical analysis

2025

PURCHASES

Different mixes of spending across places

Gao, Han & Song / mainly data to 2024

2026

ACTIVITY SPACES

Home, work and other activities can be closer or further apart

Xiao, Cai & Zhang / 2023 data

Shen (2014) [3]; Gao, Han & Song (2025) [4]; Xiao, Cai & Zhang (2026) [5]

Different geographies, periods and methods; these studies do not form a single before-and-after series.

HOW THE INQUIRY WAS BUILT

TWELVE SETS OF NOTES. TWO EXPERT DISCUSSIONS.

12

Informal conversations and visits

Including one Sheung Shui visit with three brief chats

2

Separate expert discussions

Read alongside studies, official statistics and programme documents

Illustrative experiences, not a representative interview sample

Research method and current source notes [7–8]

Twelve mixed records, not twelve interviewees. The three Sheung Shui chats belong to one visit record.

AN ADAPTED WAY TO READ THE MATERIAL

THREE LENSES

A **Livelihoods and choices**
Household choices and local business conditions

B **Everyday services and navigation**
Practical information and services people encounter

C **Relationships and support**
Ties that continue and connections that develop

Institutions run across all three.

Selected themes adapted from Arup / Resilient Cities Network, City Resilience Framework (2024) [6]

These are study lenses, not official framework dimensions or a measured resilience score.

FOUR RECURRING ACCOUNTS

PEOPLE WE WILL RETURN TO

R

Repair customer

Specialist parts and expertise

D

Dining visitors

Choice, space and price

G

Guide who moved north

A preferred occupation

P

Professional with Shenzhen ties

Work here, ties across

Illustrative accounts and field observations [7]

Letters are navigation markers, not portraits or pseudonyms. Accounts are paraphrased; arrangements overlap.

FOUR OVERLAPPING ARRANGEMENTS

A LIFE DOESN'T MOVE ALL AT ONCE

	HOME	WORK / STUDY	USE	TIES
Cross-border user	Mainly one side	Not established	Selected visits	Not established
Guide who moved north	HK to Shenzhen	Guiding	Not established	Family in HK
Worker or student	One side	The other side	Not established	Not established
Professional with ties	Rents in HK	Hong Kong	Shenzhen	Shenzhen

16,139 daily cross-boundary pupils, 2024/25

388 kindergarten + 2,577 primary + 13,174 secondary

Individual accounts [7]; Education Bureau, 2026/27 Estimates, annex table 1 [9]

Official schooling evidence; no firsthand commuter account. Mainland homes are not necessarily Shenzhen.

LOCALLY BASED ACCOUNTS / SHEUNG SHUI

CROSSING CAN BE AN OCCASIONAL CHOICE

M

Sheung Shui store manager

About monthly meals in Shenzhen; most shopping remains in Hong Kong.

N

Sheung Shui resident

Crosses infrequently; describes crowding as a reason.

E

Sheung Shui shop employee

Describes an estate shop serving mainly nearby residents.

Sheung Shui visit: three brief chats and walking observations, 31 October 2026 [8]

Three separate accounts. Staff perspectives are not measured market shares, and this is not a local population sample.

LENS A / HOUSEHOLD CHOICES

WHAT MAKES THE CROSSING WORTHWHILE?

R

Repair customer

Parts and specialist expertise that were difficult to find in Hong Kong.

D

Dining visitors

Choice, space and price; online shopping also expands the alternatives.

A capability. An experience. A selected purchase.

Repair customer and dining visitors: reported experiences and observation [7]

Paraphrases, not quotations. A cross-border visit and an online purchase are different ways of accessing alternatives.

LENS A / PUBLISHED CONSUMPTION EVIDENCE

THE MIX OF PURCHASES DIFFERS BY PLACE

MAINLAND SPENDING

About half

on services

Among established AlipayHK users who spent in Mainland China

HONG KONG SPENDING

Retail & dining

were more prominent in their local spending mix.

Gao, Han & Song / CUHK working paper (March 2025), mainly data through 2024 [4]

Mainland coverage is broader than Shenzhen. Basket differences do not identify displaced Hong Kong spending.

LENS A / A LARGER HOUSEHOLD CHANGE

A MORE WORKABLE WORK-LIFE BALANCE

G

Guide who moved north

Prepared financially and moved to pursue guiding, a long-held ambition.

Lower earnings

As described in her account

Lower living costs

Part of her calculation

Preferred work

Tour guiding

Her priorities explain the choice; no financial audit was made.

Guide who moved north: participant's account [7]

Reported trade-offs and aspirations; no verified household saving, population estimate or claim that every mover benefits.

LENS A / LOCAL BUSINESS CONDITIONS

DIFFERENT CUSTOMERS. DIFFERENT ROUTINES.

E

Sheung Shui shop employee

Estate shop: mainly nearby residents, with few tourists described.

M

Sheung Shui store manager

Landmark North: local customers and Mainland visitors; busier Monday to Thursday.

Lunch near work

Tied to a daily location and time

Planned leisure meal

More scope to choose where to go

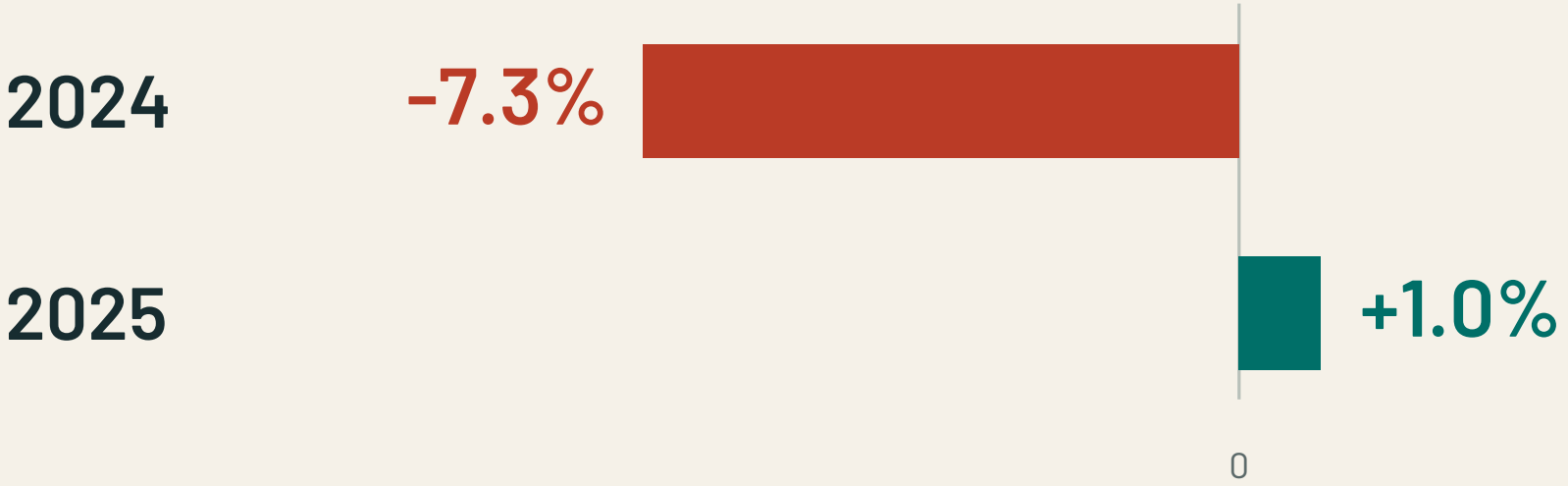
Sheung Shui store manager and shop employee [8]; guide's restaurant comparison [7]

Staff views and one participant's interpretation; no measured customer shares or causal business-impact estimate.

LENS A / CITYWIDE CONTEXT

RETAIL CHANGED ACROSS YEARS

ANNUAL CHANGE IN HONG KONG RETAIL-SALES VALUE



Local reports of fewer crowds need comparable footfall data.

Census and Statistics Department, retail-sales value [10]; Sheung Shui accounts and observation [8]

Value, not volume. These citywide changes do not isolate the effect of Shenzhen or establish a local footfall trend.

LENS A / TAKEAWAY

SELECTIVE CHOICES. DIFFERENT PRESSURES.

Shenzhen offers choices in price, specialist services and experiences.

Use depends on time, convenience and crowding. Businesses face different pressures across purchases and customer groups.

Synthesis of selected accounts, published consumption research and retail context [4, 7–8, 10]

An exploratory finding; no estimate of net welfare, representative household gains or causal business losses.

LENS B / FUTIAN ARRIVAL AND GUIDANCE

TWO DIFFERENT FORMS OF HELP

ARRIVAL PROCESS

Immigration staff directed Jamie to the required arrival-form kiosk.

NEAR THE EXIT

Staffed help points offered practical information about living and everyday services.



Guides beneath the service-centre sign

Futian visit and dated field-note addendum [7]; photograph supplied by Bob and Jamie

Separate forms of assistance. Operator unconfirmed; a completed referral was not tested. The photo documents information on display.

LENS B / COMMERCIAL SERVICES IN VIEW

EVERYDAY SERVICES AROUND THE CROSSING



VISIBLE STOREFRONTS

Dental care

Delivery services

Phones and SIM cards

The property agent described restaurants catering to Hong Kong tastes and tuition for Hong Kong-curriculum students.

Futian field observation, property-agent account [7]; original photograph supplied by Bob and Jamie

Visible provision and reported offerings are distinct. No claim about users' identities, service quality or outcomes.

LENS B / A PUBLISHED HEALTHCARE ARRANGEMENT

FOLLOW-UP CARE ACROSS THE BORDER

>5,900

eligible Hospital Authority patients joined the HKU–Shenzhen Hospital follow-up pilot by January 2026.

- **Consultations**
- **Medical records**
- **Return referrals**

HKSAR Government replies, 25 February and 17 June 2026 [12]

Defined eligibility and separate arrangements. Programme use does not establish clinical outcomes or universal coverage.

LENS B / TAKEAWAY

GUIDANCE AND SERVICES FOR CROSS-BORDER NEEDS

Practical information offers a starting point for unfamiliar arrangements.

Nearby businesses offer services relevant to people moving between the two places.

Futian and Sheung Shui observations and accounts [7–8]; published care arrangements [12]

Observed and reported provision; effectiveness, service quality and completed referrals were not assessed here.

LENS C / CONTINUING CONNECTIONS

HOME AND TIES CAN OCCUPY DIFFERENT PLACES

	HONG KONG	SHENZHEN
P **Professional with Shenzhen ties**	Work and rented home	Property, family and friends
G **Guide who moved north**	Family visits	Home and community life

Professional with Shenzhen ties and guide who moved north: participant accounts [7]

No regular commute or population prevalence inferred. Property ownership is one person's explanation of feeling at home.

LENS C / HELP THROUGH CONNECTIONS

A USEFUL LEAD. HELP AT A LATER STEP.

G

Guide who moved north

Friends shared a guiding opportunity. Someone at the organisation later helped her obtain work.

01 Friends

Information about an opportunity to qualify as a guide

02 Organisation

Intervention after reported age-related reluctance to offer work

Guide who moved north: reported sequence [7]

A particular account; not a general age rule, verified licensing requirement or evidence of qualification recognition.

LENS C / JOINING NEW CIRCLES

WORK AND SHARED INTERESTS CREATE ENTRY POINTS

G SHENZHEN

Guiding friendships

Sports and interest groups

Food-related activities

D HONG KONG

Sports leagues and coaching

Volunteering

Animal activities and beach cleaning

The guide considered Mandarin useful for joining local circles.

Guide and dining visitors: reported examples [7]

The dining group discussed Hong Kong activities during a Shenzhen visit. Examples do not establish programme effects.

LENS C / TAKEAWAY

TIES CONTINUE. NEW CONNECTIONS FORM.

Moving home or working elsewhere need not replace existing relationships.

Work and shared interests can provide entry points into new circles.

Synthesis of the guide, professional and dining visitors' accounts [7]

Specific accounts of connections and help; no population measure of belonging, cohesion or economic effects.

RETURNING TO SINGAPORE–JOHOR

CARRY THE QUESTIONS. FIND THE ANSWERS LOCALLY.

SPENDING

Which purchases, customers and locations change?

LIVES

What becomes feasible, and what stays connected across the border?

Different work, residence and service arrangements.

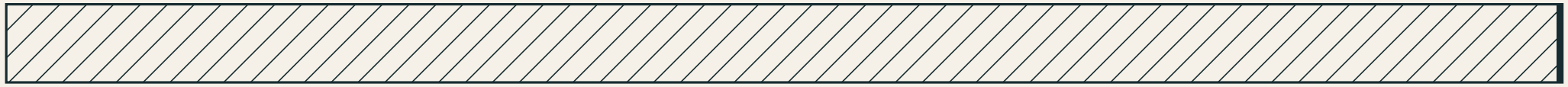
Singapore–Johor questions / JS-SEZ factsheet [1]; RTS timing [2]

Singapore and Malaysia are separate countries. Similar journeys do not imply the same rights or outcomes.

SINGAPORE–JOHOR / RTS SPENDING FORECAST

SPENDING IN BOTH DIRECTIONS

Singapore consumers to Johor Bahru



S$1.05bn

Johor Bahru consumers to Singapore



S$756m

About S$290m net incremental outflow

Additional annual consumer spending / S$ million / hatch = forecast

SBF / RAS / SRA commissioned RTS study, 16 July 2026 [13]

Forecasts, not realised spending, GDP or JS-SEZ effects. Rounded gross inputs imply S$294m; source reports about S$290m.

SINGAPORE–JOHOR / CONDITIONAL INTEREST

IF TRAVEL BECAME EASIER...

Around 1 in 3

Singapore respondents could envisage buying a JB home and retiring there.

Work or lifestyle

Family ties

Care and services

Finances

Blackbox Research, SensingSG, February 2024 [14]

Conditional stated interest, not observed migration or one-third of all Singaporeans. Household requirements are questions to explore.

SINGAPORE–JOHOR / WHO IS ALREADY THERE?

KEEP JOHOR RESIDENTS IN THE PICTURE

Opportunities

Local businesses, suppliers and workers

Access

Housing and everyday services

As RTS use develops, compare actual experience with forecasts before selecting a response.

Singapore–Johor questions / exploratory comparison

This project has not assessed these effects. Johor is more than a lower-cost option for incoming households.

WHAT THIS EXPLORATORY STUDY CONTRIBUTES

EVERYDAY EXPERIENCES MAKE INTEGRATION CONCRETE

A Choices and competitive pressures differ across purchases, customer groups, convenience and time.

B People encounter guidance and everyday services aimed at cross-border needs.

C Relationships can continue across cities while new connections form through work and shared interests.

QUESTIONS FOR FURTHER WORK

FOLLOW THE EVERYDAY EXPERIENCE

SPENDING

Purchase, customer and location

ADJUSTMENT

Workers' and firms' next steps

PRACTICAL STEPS

What enables a wanted opportunity

Explore the research

Research and presentation: Jamie Ko / Visual support: Bob

Selected experiences and questions for further inquiry. Full sources, fieldwork and interactive research accompany this presentation.